



Standing tall: A continuing education program and participatory study offered to arts therapists working in the Israeli education system^{★★,★,☆☆,☆}

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ABSTRACT

This article is based on an arts-based participatory action research study conducted as an integral part of the Standing Tall continuing education program. Focusing on arts therapists within the Israeli education system, the research investigated their perceptions of the state of creative arts therapies in the system, their experiences, and their suggestions for enhancing their work environment. Finally, it explored co-researchers' perceptions of the meaningfulness of their involvement in the program and participatory research initiative. The 20 arts therapists-co-researchers who participated in this program conducted interviews with 142 colleagues to learn about their job experiences and then analyzed these interviews. The lead researchers thematically analyzed the written and artistic materials collected during the program. The research findings showed the participants, both co-researchers, and interviewees, perceived the integration of arts therapy into the educational system as significant and potentially beneficial. The co-researchers aspired to play an active role in enhancing this integration while acknowledging the challenges involved. They saw the program as a meaningful opportunity for arts-based self-exploration. The findings suggest that while decision-makers play a crucial role in shaping the working conditions of arts therapists, the therapists themselves can catalyze change in the educational system and perhaps in other public systems as well.

★★ 2. Mindel, I., Mussa, A., Roginsky, E., Regev, D., Sender Katz, H., Rotem-Ert, T., Weisberger, I., Lidar, Y., Berman, L., Shor-Levin, L., Shwartz, L., Adler-Gavrieli, M., Simonsohn, M., Meir-Rotem, N., Bercowski-Front, A., Weber Levitzky, S., Sher, A., Atlas-Cohen, A., Ron, K., Kowalsky, S., Toker, S., Snir, S., & Sade-Dor, T. (2023). The status of arts therapy in Israel's education system in 2022. *Academic Journal: Creative Arts Therapies*, 12(2), 1367–1386. ★ 1. Sade-Dor, T., Snir, S., Toker, S., Kowalsky, S., Ron, K., Atlas-Cohen, A., Sher, A., Weber Levitzky, S., Bercowski-Front, A., Meir-Rotem, N., Simonsohn, M., Simonsohn, M., Adler-Gavrieli, M., Shwartz, L., Shor-Levin, L., Berman, L., Lidar, Y., Weisberger, I., Rotem-Ert, T., Sender Katz, H., Regev, D., Roginsky, E., Mussa, A., & Mindel, I. (2023). The 'Standing Tall' project: Training and collaborative research for art therapists employed in the education system. *Academic Journal: Creative Arts Therapies*, 12(2), 1349–1366.★★ This paper is an adapted version of research previously published in Hebrew as two separate papers:★ The Standing Tall program was supported by the Interdisciplinary Research Center for Arts and Spirituality: Therapy, Education and Society, Tel Hai College, Israel, and by the Israeli Ministry of Education. We have no conflicts of interest to disclose.

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Sometimes, when a storm is raging, the rain is falling heavily and the winds are howling, you can choose to stand outside, get wet, and complain. But you can also go inside for a moment and consider what you want to do right now.

– Amani, co-researcher –

Education systems worldwide recognize the need to address not only the academic but also the behavioral and emotional needs of students (e.g., National Institute for Health and Care Excellence, 2023; US Department of Education, 2020). Thus, schools can become strategic venues for delivering therapeutic interventions (Tejada-Gallardo et al., 2020). In Israel, with the enactment of the Special Education Law in 1988 and its subsequent amendment in 2002, there has been a marked increase in the integration of arts therapists into the educational system, especially to support students with special educational needs (see Snir et al., 2018). At the end of 2023, approximately 4000 creative arts therapists were employed in the Israeli education system (E. Roginsky, personal communication, 2024) with the purpose of enabling students to realize their potential, develop their abilities, skills, and preferences, and grow into independent and autonomous adults who integrate into society as equal participants, experience a life of quality, and participate in all areas of life (Israeli Ministry of Education, 2018). Most of these therapists are employed in special education schools through the Special Education Division or in Regional Support Centers (RSCs), which provide services to eligible children integrated into the regular education system. Offering creative arts therapies within a child's natural environment, specifically within the education system, may be a solution for children who might otherwise not have access to therapy (Snir & Regev, 2021). However, as the research literature from Israel and elsewhere reveals, the integration of arts therapy into a large system whose primary focus is education involves immense challenges that arise from the encounter between the distinct and different therapeutic and educational fields (Snir et al., 2018). Challenges in integrating arts therapy into schools include issues of privacy and confidentiality (Frieman, 2021), the need to redefining the role of arts therapy (Seo et al., 2024), and difficulties encountered by therapists participating in staff meetings (Hautala, 2011). Other challenges are related to the educational staff's understanding and support of the arts therapy process (Deboys et al., 2016). Specific obstacles include unsuitable rooms for conducting arts therapy, a lack of necessary equipment and materials (Glassman & Prasad, 2013), and a misalignment between the school's schedule and the continuity needed for effective therapy (Simon, 2016). These difficulties escalated during the COVID-19 pandemic, and new challenges emerged for care professionals, including adapting to remote healthcare delivery, handling high caseloads, dealing with the psychological impacts of a prolonged crisis and the emotional strain involved in client care (Humer & Probst, 2020; Probst et al., 2020; Thompson-de Benoit & Kramer, 2021), and coping with burnout (De Kock et al., 2021; Gold, 2020; Preti et al., 2020; Stuijzand et al., 2020). Arts therapists in general (Carr, 2020) and those working in the education system in particular (Hacohen et al., 2022) were required to cope with new realities that demanded creativity and resilience. In Israel, given their high-stress roles, many felt their work was undervalued by the educational systems they served (Personal communication). During 2021–2022, a significant number of arts therapists either resigned or took unpaid leave, and replacements were slow to come forward. According to YAHAT, the Israeli Association for Creative Arts Therapies, as of 2022, 260 arts therapist positions in the education system remained unfilled (Yasour & Dvir, 2022).

In view of these factors, and with the support of the national supervisors in the Special Education Division of the Ministry of Education, a continuing education program named Standing Tall was established. The aim was to allow experience arts therapists to explore and conceptualize their difficulties, reflect on their experiences as arts therapists in the educational system, and consider what they could do

for themselves, their supervisees, colleagues, their clients, and their profession in general. The program was accompanied by participatory research because past experiences have shown that participation in research leads to growth and empowerment among creative arts therapists working in the education system (Snir et al., 2023). It was designed to be based on current, real-life experiences in the field, and this knowledge was to be shared with other therapists and professionals in the education system, with the purpose of sharing relevant practice implications.

The present study drew on the research conducted as part of the Standing Tall program and asked the following questions. First, what is the state of creative arts therapy in the education system in Israel, and how do arts therapists experience their working environment? Second, what would the co-researchers like to change in their work environments? Third, how was participation in the Standing Tall program and participatory research significant for the co-researchers?

Method

An integral part of the Standing Tall continuing education program was an action study (Campbell, 2010), in which program participants acted as co-researchers. The initiative for the program emerged from interactions with arts therapists in a previous study the leading researchers conducted within the educational system. A supervisor expressed her desire to empower the therapists she supervised, encouraging them to be more confident and less burnt out and to 'stand taller.' In response, we embarked on the continuing education program, appropriately naming it Standing Tall to reflect the core objective of enhancing therapists' resilience and stature within their professional practice.

The framework of Standing Tall aligns with participatory action research (Cornwall & Jewkes, 1995), an approach where participants are not only subjects but also co-contributors to the research process, actively influencing the direction and outcomes of the study. In this case, the arts therapists, serving as both program participants and co-researchers, were actively involved in the investigation, analysis, and reporting stages. Their engagement was focused on addressing changeable aspects of their work environments, fostering their own empowerment, and furthering their professional development (Abma et al., 2019). As the research method included artmaking as a means of self-exploration, this study can also be considered arts-based participatory research (Kapitan et al., 2011).

The continuing education program

The continuing education program included two Zoom sessions and an intensive two-day workshop. During the workshop, the co-researchers engaged in a joint investigation of their experiences in the education system and of elements in their work that helped them 'stand taller.' This investigation was carried out using various collaborative formats, alternating between small group sessions and larger group discussions, allowing diverse interactions and collective insights. As part of the program, the co-researchers were given two assignments. First, at the beginning of the program, they interviewed their colleagues at the RSC to learn about their experiences working in the education system and then wrote an essay summarizing these interviews. Second, toward the end of the program, they wrote a proposal for a project that could promote the work of therapists and enhance the quality of their work experiences in the education system. The co-researchers received 30 h of approved professional development for their participation. For more details on the goals, interventions, and tasks of the various program components, see Table 1.

Leading researchers and co-researchers

Twenty-three female creative arts therapists participated in this

Table 1
Program Components, Goals, and Interventions.

Place and duration of meeting	Goals of the meeting	Interventions for achieving the goal	Raw research materials produced in these meetings
Zoom, two hours	Getting acquainted Presenting the initiative Coordinating expectations	Group discussion	
Zoom, three hours	Empowerment Preliminary expression of the work experiences of creative arts therapists who work in the education system.	Presentation of research findings underlining the important contribution of creative arts therapists Each co-researcher chose a song/poem that expressed her experience and shared it via YouTube with the group, explaining its significance. A brief discussion followed. First assignment (in the field): In your workplace, interview creative arts therapists about their experiences and the challenges of working in the education system. Try to gain access to a wide variety of voices, including those that differ from your own. Prepare a summary of the different voices you heard (at least ten different points that emerged from the conversations).	The songs chosen. Explanations pertaining to the choices. Discussions in the plenum pertaining to the choices. First task Summarizing the voices that emerged from the interviews.
In-person workshop, first day	Educating on compassion fatigue and burnout Structured thematic analysis of the interviews that co-researchers conducted with their colleagues. Encouraging activism and entrepreneurship as a way to create change. The expression of my experience in the education system	Research-based presentation and discussion Working in small groups to analyze all the interviews conducted by co-researchers, followed by a discussion in the plenum designed to integrate all the information into a cohesive thematic framework. Presentation of participatory studies that have promoted activism and entrepreneurship. Each participant was asked to choose another song/poem which reflected hope and strengths in the context of her work in the education system. Before each choice was presented, we asked each participant to think of the previous song/poem she chose and describe the progression from that choice to her current one.	
In person workshop, second day	Release and relaxation Expressing the personal experience of working in the education system Investigating the question: What helps me 'stand taller' when working in the education system? Choosing future courses of action Receiving feedback: the significance of participating in this project.	Movement activity Co-researchers were invited to an arts-based activity that involved drawing a tree and then connecting their tree to a forest, as a metaphor of their experiences working as creative arts therapists in the education system. The first instruction was: 'I invite you to think about yourself within the education system. Think about the path you have taken; about the things you have done; about the places in which you have grown; about the places in which you have wilted; about what you have given to others; about what you have received; and about the challenges you have encountered. Think of yourself in terms of a tree. A tree that was planted many years ago. A tree that grows and meets people, nurturing places, and challenges. Take an A3 –4 sheet of paper and draw yourself as a tree.' After preparing the drawing, each participant positioned her tree within the common space. Observation of the tree, its location, and its surroundings. Each participant reflected on what would help her tree 'stand taller.' They were then instructed to use oil chalks to add elements representing what a tree needs in terms of its connections and place on the common substrate. We invited them to look at the trees again, surrounded by the nutrients that could help it 'stand taller,' and to reflect on what they saw, what the drawing conveyed beyond its initial intention. Experiences were shared in small groups. In the plenum, each group presented one central issue that arose in this discussion. In addition, each participant wrote down the factors that helped her tree 'stand taller.' Plenary discussion, work in small groups and the second assignment: writing a proposal for a project that can promote the work of therapists and improve their experiences.	Creative outcomes Group discussion following artmaking Group and plenary discussions on courses of action. Second task: project proposal Summary group discussion

study, reflecting the predominance of women in the field of arts therapy within the education system. Three of these were the lead facilitators. One was a music therapist who was working as a supervisor for the Hefer

Sharon RSC and is currently a national supervisor in the Special Education Division at the Ministry of Education. The other two were arts therapists who had worked in the education system in the past. All had

Table 2
Additional Information on Co-Researchers.

	Age	Position in education system	Modality	Seniority as a creative arts therapist (number of years)	Seniority in the education system (number of years)	Number of therapists the co-researcher interviewed for the first assignment
1	38	Supervisor and expert in the field	Drama	13	12	5
2	48	Instructor	Art	10	9	5
3	57	Therapist, supervisor	Art	10	9	5
4	49	Therapists, interning towards an supervisor position	Art	10	24	4
5	39	Therapist, school coordinator for creative arts therapies	Bibliotherapy	11	9	5
6	53	Therapist, supervisor, expert in the field	Dance/movement	24	21	9
7	42	Therapist	Dance/movement	13	13	4
8	49	Therapist, supervisor, expert in the field of creative arts therapies	Art	18	18	9
9	54	Therapist, expert in the field., arts therapies coordinator, supervisor	Art	28	28	10
10	47	Therapist, supervisor, expert in the field	Bibliotherapy	17	17	8
11	60	Supervisor and expert in creative arts therapies	Art	13	33	8
12	47	Therapist, expert in the field	Art	18	21	8
13	49	Therapist, school coordinator for creative arts therapies	Art	7	7	15
14	55	Therapist, supervisor	Art	22	22	8
15	52	Therapist	Art	12	12	6
16	55	Therapist, supervisor	Art	22	26	6
17	47	Therapist, school coordinator for creative arts therapies	Art	14	23	5
18	48	Coordinator for creative arts therapies in RSC	Dance/movement	22	22	9
19	53	Therapist, specializes in ASD	Art	13	12	9
20	59	Therapist, supervisor	Music	26	26	4
						Total number of interviewees = 142

expertise in the field of arts therapies research and had been involved in research at the University of Haifa and Tel Hai College on arts therapies in the education system. The 20 co-researchers worked as senior creative arts therapists within the education system, most in management positions (see Table 2). They were invited to participate in the program in April 2022, by means of an ad sent out by the national creative arts therapy supervisors in the Special Education Division of the Ministry of Education. The first 20 therapists to register were accepted into the program. Two additional therapists were accepted in place of two from the original list who cancelled their participation.

The initiative for the program emerged from a collaboration between the lead researchers and some of the co-researchers, with the support of the two Israel Department of Education national arts therapist supervisors. The program was designed by the lead researchers, who also guided the co-researchers through the investigation process and data analysis and led the writing. The co-researchers conducted interviews with other arts therapists, analyzed the data, and served as auditors during the writing process (See Table 2).

Data collection

The data included two written assignments and materials collected during the workshop sessions: selected songs/poems and explanations for these selections, art products and discussions around them, and plenary discussions (see Table 1 for more details).

Procedure and data analysis

Analysis of the first assignment: interviews with colleagues

The lead researchers printed out the summaries of the interviews submitted by the co-researchers for the first assignment. Under the guidance of the lead researchers, the co-researchers thematically analyzed the data during the final in-person session in early July 2022.

This analysis followed the methodology outlined by Clarke and Braun (2017), adapted to facilitate a group process. Initially, the co-researchers were organized into groups of five, as depicted in Fig. 1.

Each co-researcher read her written summary to the others in her group. This reading corresponds to the first stage of the thematic analysis, familiarizing oneself with the text. Following this, in accordance with the second stage of thematic analysis, the initial coding phase, the co-researchers segmented the summaries and grouped pieces with similar statements together (see Fig. 2).

In accordance with the third stage of thematic analysis, the co-researchers reflected together on potential themes and gave names to



Fig. 1. Thematic Analysis Conducted in Groups. Note: Working in groups, co-researchers analyzed the interviews they conducted with RSC colleagues ahead of the workshop.

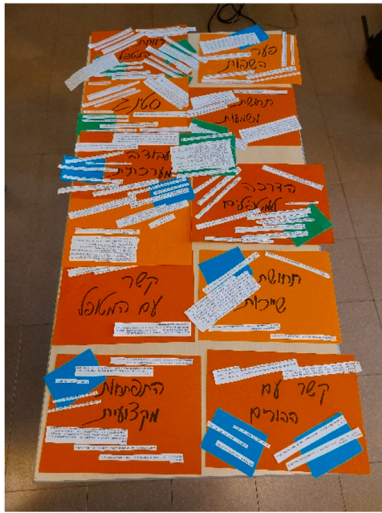


Fig. 2. Outcomes of Thematic Analysis. Note: Each group of co-researchers created a poster with the results of its thematic analysis. The themes represent the experience of arts therapists working in the education system.

each group of similar statements. Then the lead researchers and co-researchers convened in the plenum, where they conducted the fourth phase of the thematic analysis, defining the themes (see Fig. 3).

A thematic map was created on the board during the plenum. It underwent changes and adjustments, based on the content added from the various groups. The lead researchers continued the analysis process a week later when they reviewed the raw materials again, including the personal summaries of each of the co-researchers, and verified that the thematic map created in the plenum conformed to the original raw material. Thus, in keeping with the fifth stage of thematic analysis, the themes were named, and the list was finalized.

In the sixth and final phase, drafting the report, the lead researchers worked on the descriptions of each theme until there was consensus. Finally, a summary report was sent to all co-researchers, who were invited to make comments and corrections based on further examination of the raw material and personal perceptions.

Analysis of remaining materials

The lead researchers conducted a thematic analysis of all the materials collected during the workshop sessions: the selected songs and accompanying explanations of the choices, the art products and the discussions around them, discussions in the plenum, and the second written assignment. In the first phase, familiarization with the text, one of the lead researchers reviewed the materials. In the second phase, the

initial coding phase, the same researcher marked topics and ideas that arose from the texts. She also conducted the third phase of analysis that involved defining the themes, while the fourth stage, scrutinizing the themes in relation to the raw materials, was done by another lead researcher. The three lead researchers conducted the fifth step of the analysis together; this involved finalizing and naming the themes. After the sixth and final stage, writing up the themes, was complete, the lead researchers sent a written summary to the co-researchers for their review and comments. The formulations and descriptions of the assorted topics were adjusted based on feedback, until all co-researchers agreed.

Trustworthiness and reflexivity

To ensure reflexivity in the research, we adopted two strategies. First, the analysis was conducted in stages, initially in small groups of co-researchers, followed by discussions in the full assembly of leading and collaborating researchers. The consideration of the findings continued among the leading researchers, with three stages of discussion on the implications of the findings. Second, the written findings were sent for reflexive contemplation to each of the 23 researchers, fostering an additional dialogue, this time in writing, among all 23 researchers.

Ethics

At the outset of this initiative, the co-researchers were briefed on the participatory nature of the research and were invited to contribute. It was clearly communicated that they would receive the continued education credit regardless of their decision to participate. Moreover, they were assured they could continue in the program even if they chose to withdraw from the research at any point. When conducting interviews for the first assignment, the co-researchers were instructed to preserve the anonymity of their interviewees and not to use the information they received in any way in their collaborations with RSCs. The study was approved by the Ethics Committee of the Faculty of Social Welfare and Health Sciences at the University of Haifa (Approval No. 2946) and by the Chief Scientist in the Ministry of Education (Approval No. 12489).

Findings

This section outlines the research findings for each of the three research questions in turn.

The state of creative arts therapies in Israel

The first research question asked: Based on the perspective of therapists working in the system, what is the state of the creative arts therapies in the education system in Israel in 2022, and how do these

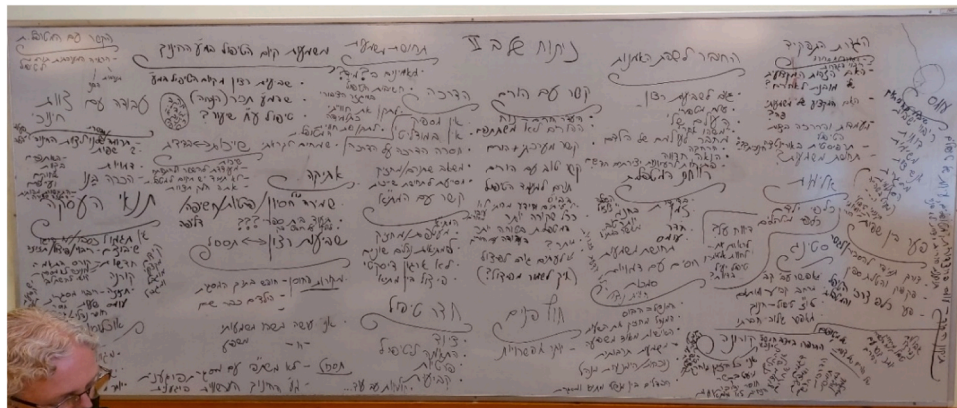


Fig. 3. Board Showing Themes Identified in the Plenum. Note: In the plenum, each group of co-researchers presented the themes it found, and these were listed on the board.

Table 3
Themes and Initial Codes.

Theme	Initial codes based on analysis of the selected songs and the discussion that followed	Initial codes based on analysis of the tree and forest drawings and the discussion that followed	Initial codes based on analysis of the first interview assignment
Creative arts therapists in the education system perceive their work as meaningful for their student-clients and professionally fulfilling.	Working with students is meaningful. There is a sense of mission and values.	The tree bearing fruit signifies the work done within the system.	The choice of public service stems from a sense of mission and is related to the opportunity to do meaningful and valuable work. Successful therapy and recognizing that the selected medium has contributed brings with it a sense of fulfillment. Working in an organized framework provides job security. The status of therapists and their profession is improving. Suitable working conditions are a source of support and unity. Providing emotional support increases employee retention. Professional advancement increases employee retention.
The opportunity to engage in systemic work and establish relationships with teachers and staff are factors that strengthen and motivate the therapist and make her more resilient.	The therapists need the contact and warmth of teachers and staff to feel strong and resilient.	Therapists need to feel that they belong, and they believe that effective teamwork and mutual support are sources of strength. They need the recognition and appreciation of those around them.	The opportunity to engage in systemic work strengthens the therapist and contributes to her effectiveness. Quality teamwork in an educational setting promotes efficiency, professional fulfillment, and a sense of belonging.
The creative arts therapist's job is complex and includes many challenges that add to the already heavy workload.	Working as a therapist in the education system involves difficulties and challenges: the need to carve out an identity, the heavy burden of students' pain; maintaining confidentiality; the challenges of teamwork; a sense of loneliness and foreignness; the need for refuge and order; the need to cope with chaos and disorganization.	'Blood sweat and tears' - trees that experience hardships along the way. The sense that teachers and staff do not see them. A very demanding job with a lot of restrictions.	Difficulties related to the nature of employment through the Ministry of Education: a lot of red tape connected to employment and working conditions; insufficient financial compensation that is thought unfair; persistent uncertainty in many areas that undermines their feeling of security; numerous procedures that increase the workload, a heavy client load and the extra work involved for each client beyond the hour of therapy; work with diverse institutions that is often exhausting; and a frustrating lack of attractive opportunities for professional advancement. Difficulties related to the need to carve out a professional identity and standing: the professional identity of creative arts therapist working in the education system is not sufficiently clear. Sometimes the conditions in the school do not enable a professional level of therapy. Training provided by the RSCs is helpful but not always sufficient. Continuing professional education programs provided to therapists are not always relevant or tailored to their specific needs. Difficulties related to communication with teachers and staff and systemic work: divergent perceptions among therapeutic and educational teams, lack of time and the financial resources needed for efficient staff communications; insufficient parental engagement; unsatisfactory conditions for working with parents; inequalities and communication difficulties with tangential professions (such as educational psychologists), and sometimes insufficient support from RSCs.

therapists experience their working environment?

An answer to this research question was provided by integrating data from the analysis of the first assignment, i.e., 142 interviews that co-researchers conducted with their colleagues, the selection of the songs/poems and the discussions around these choices, and the art products from the tree and forest drawing task, including the discussion following this activity. The data were integrated only after a separate thematic analysis was conducted for each source (see Table 3).

Creative arts therapists perceive their work as meaningful for their clients, and professionally fulfilling

Both groups in this study (co-researchers and interviewees) described the work of creative arts therapists employed within the education system as meaningful; in their view, their mission was to provide arts therapy to students who would otherwise not have access to therapy. For many, this work embodied a social ideal, and they described the deeply rewarding experience of witnessing positive transformations in their clients as a result of therapy. For example, one co-researcher chose the Israeli song 'I have love' (Duchin, 1995) to symbolize the sense of strength and inner fulfillment that come with therapeutic work, citing the line, 'Among the confusion and disaster, know that there is a solution, it's called love.'

Job security and gradually improving working conditions

Both interviewees and co-researchers noted that employment within the education system offers job security. They said working in the mornings in an organized workplace and having paid vacations allowed them to raise a family with relative convenience. They noted the gradual but significant improvement in their professional standing and career advancement and employment conditions. When work conditions were favorable and they could function effectively, they said they felt better connected to their jobs and experience less burnout.

Systemic work and establishing relationships with teachers and staff build resilience and motivation

Both interviewees and co-researchers found forging close relationships with teachers and staff, collaborating with colleagues, and feeling they were an integral part of a cohesive work team to be emotionally sustaining. The RSCs were often described as a benevolent authority and a reference group that could focus and strengthen their professional identity. Working in a multi-professional framework allowed them to engage in systemic holistic work that benefited the students; both groups expressed the desire to strengthen their ties with principals, additional representatives from the RSC, and homeroom teachers. When drawing their trees in the workshop, many of the co-researchers drew roots, reflecting their firm grounding and sense of connection to sources of sustainment. The branches and leaves were sometimes described as arms that connected to others in the system. Some said the proximity to other trees (see Fig. 4) stressed the shift from lone tree to forest and prompted them to think about their connections to their work environment. As facilitators observing this activity from the sidelines, the lead researchers saw the enthusiasm that emerged when the co-researchers worked together, as if there was real hunger for an encounter of this kind. One of the co-researchers said: 'The part about connecting was inspiring; it gave us the strength to be, to grow, and reminded us of the existence of connections in our work in the education system.' The co-researchers found the relationships formed during the workshop were both sustaining and calming; these new connections reaffirmed their belief that loneliness is harmful and damaging and allowed them to experience the power of a community that comes together to help itself. This sparked questions as to which personal and professional relationships they should foster in their daily work. What relationships should you avoid? How do you learn, and how do you teach therapists to cultivate professional ties? How do you help therapists position themselves better (i.e., move from a position of isolation to a position of collaboration) within the system?



Fig. 4. *Creating a Forest*. Note: Co-researchers connect the images they prepared in the shared space.

The work of creative arts therapist in the education system is complicated and includes many challenges that add to their already heavy workload

The interviewees and co-researchers all described their arts therapist jobs as extremely challenging, despite the many advantages. The tree drawings of some of the co-researchers reflected these difficulties, with images of trees bent over in the wind and storms of 'blood, sweat and tears that leave their mark on the bark of the tree trunks' (Fig. 5).

A main challenge identified by both interviewees and co-researchers was the need to work in a large and complicated system in which the work conditions are unclear. They mentioned low salaries that disregard their professional experience: 'Our employment conditions are appropriate for teachers and not commensurate with the unique characteristics of our profession.' They said they had to cope with many unknowns regarding beginning of the school year changes or the list of students eligible for therapy. Many noted the endless work procedures that complicate their work. Some said they had to work in more than one school, and during the week they traveled from one to the other. In addition, they could be assigned a large number of clients, leading to increased exposure to distress, not to mention the reams of paperwork accompanying each case. The experience of having to carry a heavy burden was reflected in five of the songs and poems selected by the co-researchers during the workshop activities. One example was the poem 'Safekeeping' (Keidar, 2021): 'A child places in safekeeping his anxieties, the shadows that fill his nights, his pain and tears and all his insults, so that he can once again return to his daily life.'

A recurring theme in the interviews was the inadequately defined professional identity of creative arts therapists within the education system. Interviewees said this lack of clarity contributes to unrealistic demands and unclear expectations from the educational staff, fostering an environment of insufficient trust in their professional opinions: 'Principals do not understand our role in the school. One principal wanted me to do additional sessions with students who had already completed their therapy because they "needed to vent"'. Some interviewees said field experts from the RSCs or the principal sometimes buckle under the pressure of the growing needs of students and the shortage of money and staff, and try to persuade therapists to compromise in their work conditions and work environments. One interviewee said the RSCs consistently communicate the message that therapists need to 'make do with the resources at hand. Therapists do not have the professional liberty to decline therapy based on unfavorable conditions; they must adapt to any situation, regardless of how inadequate it may be.' Therapists observed that conflicts often arise due to the different languages spoken by educational and therapeutic staff. These conflicts



Fig. 5. *The Finished Product.* Note: Co-researchers created a forest representing their experiences working within the education system.

involve treatment goals, conduct towards students undergoing therapy, and ethical and confidentiality issues.

The interviewees and co-researchers both said that due to the lack of budget and the extended work hours, there is no time for proper staff meetings, so suitable channels of communication are not established. This impairs the multiteam and systemic care of students and leads to a sense of isolation among therapists. Many described unsatisfactory working conditions, such as unsuitable workspaces and lack of equipment and materials. In addition to the challenge of creating and maintaining a suitable physical space, the many educational activities, ceremonies, holidays, and school vacations have a negative effect on continuity of therapy: 'As a result of the artificial interruption of therapy during the summer break, students stop receiving support; that is harmful and leads to regression.'

Interviewees cited insufficient supervision and said the Ministry of Education does not offer sufficient continuing education programs addressing the unique needs of creative arts therapists. They also said arts therapists have to cope with their low status in the system compared to tangential professions, such as psychologists and other experts. Interviewees reported bouts of jealousy and professional competition that silence their voices and minimize their contribution: 'Sitting right next to me, they say to the parents of my client, "Your child needs psychological treatment, we will have to refer him to a professional."'

Proposed changes in the education system

The second research question asked what arts therapists would like to change in the education system. To answer this question, we focused on the responses of the co-researchers.

In light of the challenges, co-researchers expressed their desire to maintain a professional identity and to define the requirements and clear boundaries of their profession. The co-researchers, who were informed in advance that the workshop was an invitation to take responsibility, said arts therapists must wake up and act if they want to create change. Everyone was hopeful about the ability to create change, and many selected poems or songs reflecting this sentiment. These included the optimistic songs 'You and I will change the world' (Einstein, 1971) and 'Peaceful days' (Lola, 2000): 'Here they come, peaceful days, we're both here on the mountain, the water has already receded and there's also a rainbow. You can get up, the end of the world has passed.' During the workshop, the co-researchers expressed the strength and power that comes with faith and the ability to create change. They described many of the trees in their drawings as powerful: 'A human tree, firmly rooted in its place, with a clear identity.' Some chose to draw a thick trunk to symbolize the strength and resilience they had developed over the years. Some drew roots, as an expression of their firm grounding and their connection to sources of sustenance. They all drew foliage, and some drew fruit. Many noted that trees are constantly growing. Projects proposed by the co-researchers during group discussions, in the plenum, and in the second written assignment reflected this optimism about their ability to create change.

Strengthening the relationship between therapists and the RSC

Many of the proposed projects addressed the feelings of isolation that therapists working in the education system experience, as well as the need for maintenance, containment and belonging. These needs are not always met by the RSCs. The projects also addressed the challenges of forging a professional identity and promoting professional growth and expanded on existing RSC activities for creative arts therapists. Some suggested augmenting the existing group training programs by adding programs focused on specific target audiences or topics or tailored to employee seniority. Inspired by an existing RSC program, some co-researchers suggested conducting the training sessions on Zoom so they would be accessible to all. Other proposals included case study-based training, peer study evenings, learning from successes, and guest lectures. Some suggested expanding the scope of joint continuous education programs and workshops. The co-researchers described a project that was implemented in several RSCs, in which creative art therapists who were also artists were given a platform where they could present their work to RSC staff; the goal was to empower, inspire, and enable new connections. One proposal centered on establishing an open studio in the RSCs, where therapists could create and experiment together and expand their knowledge of the use of art materials.

Strengthening the ties between RSCs

The workshop, the listening, and the sharing ignited a desire for more frequent meetings and collaboration among co-researchers from different RSCs. One idea was to create an online forum for all creative arts therapists in the education system, where they could upload articles, presentations, and videos of projects and initiatives implemented in the various RSCs. Another idea was to hold a monthly online conference, under the auspices of the national supervisors, where RSCs could present initiatives or issues which might be of interest to all. Finally, one co-researcher suggested increasing the number of national conferences at which therapists from all RSCs would convene to study a specific subject.

Strengthening the relationship between the RSCs and therapists and between the schools, teachers, and staff

Some of the proposed projects tried to solve the therapists' need for RSC support when dealing with the schools, teachers and staff, and unsatisfactory workspaces. The co-researchers who submitted these proposals volunteered to formulate a position paper that the RSC administration would then distribute to educational frameworks, outlining the necessary conditions to implement arts therapy in schools and kindergartens. The proposed position paper would include a job description, outline the requirement for proper conditions and materials, and describe effective teamwork to ensure students receive professional care. The goal was to give therapists a suitable space to conduct their therapeutic work and allow them to provide professional solutions to students needing therapy. Work procedures pertaining to teamwork would also be included in the position paper; findings could lead to multi-professional team meetings, which are sometimes neglected because of the heavy workload.

Organizing and constructing the on-boarding of new therapists

One group of co-researchers reported that arts therapists who begin working in the education system discover there is a gap between what they learned in their studies and realities in the field. Many drop out because they do not feel adequately supported. This group proposed designing the onboarding process for new therapists, first through the creation of a workshop to learn about their needs and then followed by meetings to enable them to conceptualize their work. These meetings would provide information on the system, coordinate expectations, clarify responsibilities and terminology, such as the names of reports and committees, introduce arts therapists to available support staff and the kinds of therapy available, and discuss professional standards, issues of empowerment, and retention. The goal of the proposed onboarding program would be to increase knowledge, resilience, and confidence. Another goal was to introduce arts therapists to their rights and responsibilities at the various levels – the school, the RSC, and the wider education system – thereby facilitating the onboarding process, increasing their sense of belonging, and reducing stress, thus promoting best performance.

Creation of in-service programs focused on specific target audiences

One proposal that sought to promote professionalization and strengthen professional identity focused on the development of in-service programs geared to specific target populations. In-service training will allow the therapists to better understand the unique needs of the populations served and learn new therapeutic approaches. An accompanying support program would provide therapists with the space to acknowledge and validate emotions that come up during their work, help identify additional needs, empower therapists, and expand their toolboxes through case studies and lectures.

Presenting the profession to education professionals

One group of co-researchers proposed promoting the issue of professional branding in order to strengthen resilience and bridge gaps between arts therapists and teaching staff. This initiative would focus on expanding the repertoire of tools for the personal and professional branding of arts therapists within the education system by identifying current and future strengths and circles of influence, while raising awareness of the importance of professional branding and how it can benefit therapists, clients, and the educational system.

Significance of participating in the workshop and participatory research

The third research question asked how participation in the Standing Tall program and participatory research was significant for the co-researchers. Findings showed that the initiative provided a break, was empowering and inspirational, and instilled hope. In the workshop's concluding session, most co-researchers reported that they were able to charge their batteries and rest during the meetings. Some said they recovered and got stronger. For example, one said, 'I was sad and depressed at the RSC, and this was a turning point. I recharged my batteries. I felt like a little girl, and I allowed myself to run wild.' Some described an 'existential change,' or said they had more optimism about their work in the education system. Others were inspired to act. The optimism and new sense of strength was evident: 'The training put wind in my sails. It won't be the same as before, I can't continue to work like this.'

The structure of the workshop enhanced learning in a variety of ways. First, the co-researchers reported that listening to their colleagues helped them feel stronger and empowered; it helped them to connect to and better understand their own experiences in the education system. Working in collaboration and without conflict with a group of colleagues helped them to share a common language, toolboxes, and ideas: 'I feel that there is a collaborative voice, and that I am a part of everything that is said. These are all our voices.' Second, although the co-researchers sometimes found it challenging to create in media that were less

familiar to them (music and visual arts), their feedback indicated that the exercises gave them a new perspective on their experience and renewed their belief in the healing power and benefits of arts therapies. Third, co-researchers described the program as a meaningful learning space that provided new sensations, skills, and knowledge. Performing the interviews gave them a keen sense of mission: 'I forwarded the interview request to the RSC group.... They passed the list to a lot of RSCs, and a lot of people wanted to be interviewed. I had the feeling that I was representing a lot of people in the system.'

The workshop led co-researchers to reassess the significance of arts therapy within the education system. Their acknowledgment of the distinctive expertise required for this form of therapy infused new meaning into their decision to remain in the education system. Some said they left the workshop determined to create change: 'The choice to stay is not trivial. It is a conscious choice.... It is important and even crucial that we raise this flag. It's a different kind of therapy, justified, interesting, and creative in its own way.'

Discussion

This article describes an arts-based participatory action research study conducted as an integral part of a continuing education program for arts therapists called Standing Tall. It focusses on three key aspects: the experience of arts therapists working in the education system, recommended courses of action, and the significance of participating in a workshop and participatory research. Although the research was conducted in Israel, the findings and insights have implications for arts therapists working in public systems worldwide, offering valuable lessons for policymakers and therapists who seek to create change.

Experiences of arts therapists in the education system

Interviewees and co-researchers cited a number of positive factors when discussing their work in the education system. These included a sense of a mission and a strong desire to contribute to and support children, educators, and parents who benefit from therapeutic services in the public sector. They emphasized the importance of their work with students, particularly those who might not have access to therapy otherwise. They also spoke about the profound sense of fulfillment derived from helping children and youth within the education system.

Statements of this nature, demonstrating that arts therapists' keen sense of mission and fulfillment is a key motivating factor in their work, were less prominent in a study conducted less than a decade ago with arts therapists in the education system in Israel (Regev et al., 2015; Snir et al., 2018). It is possible that the 'Guidelines for Teaching Staff from the Health Professions and Creative Arts Therapists Who Work in the Education System' white paper (2021), designed to standardize procedures and working conditions in the Israeli educational system, has positively influenced the field and led to improvements. These guidelines and their positive impacts could serve as a model for other countries aiming to enhance the working conditions and professional satisfaction of arts therapists.

Along with the positive aspects of working in the education system, co-researchers and interviewees reported significant challenges and burnout. They said they had a heavy workload due to numerous responsibilities and mentioned the immense pressure of maintaining confidentiality, the burden of carrying the emotional pain of others entrusted to them, and their own personal distress. They further reported that collaboration with school staff was challenging. The atmosphere could be competitive and fraught with misunderstandings, resulting in feelings of isolation, a sense of foreignness, and a need for refuge, order, and personal space. They had questions and doubts about their professional identity and brought up issues of visibility and presence within educational institutions. They mentioned dealing with extensive bureaucracy during onboarding, complicated paychecks, difficulty resolving salary issues with relevant officials, and unfair

remuneration. The lack of job security was cited as an issue for new arts therapists without permanent positions and for experienced employees repeatedly transferred to new positions.

All these factors may contribute to burnout among arts therapists working in the education system. The World Health Organization classifies burnout as a syndrome that significantly affects the mental well-being, physical health, and efficiency of workers (World Health Organization, 2019). A recent study conducted among 327 educational consultants highlighted the relationship between heavy workloads and burnout. The study demonstrated that the more cases consultants oversaw, the more they perceived their work as inducing mental stress and burnout (Mullen et al., 2021). Studies examining job satisfaction in other therapeutic professions such as social work have found that in addition to the number of clients, excessive paperwork, the continuous mental effort required, and a heavy workload are causes of job dissatisfaction (e.g., Berlanda et al., 2017). A study exploring the views of teachers and arts therapists working in the education system regarding the integration of arts therapists in this system had similar findings (Snir et al., 2018). It seemed that especially after the Covid-19 pandemic, many interviewees felt the challenges and complex employment conditions of arts therapists in the education system were burdensome, increased burnout, and contributed to attrition. Considering the serious shortage of arts therapists in public service, especially in the education system, and the importance of safeguarding their professionalism and well-being, policymakers should direct their attention to employment conditions and compensation. The need for such attention is not confined to Israel; it is a pressing issue in all educational systems where arts therapists are integrated into schools and play a crucial role in student well-being (e.g., Deboys et al., 2016; Glassman & Prasad, 2013; Hautala, 2011; Seo et al., 2024; Simon, 2016).

The co-researchers emphasized the importance of sustainment when dealing with these challenges and building resilience. Sources of support they mentioned included continuing education and professional development, maintaining a connection to the arts, quality supervision, and support from the RSCs and the schools. A recurring theme that came up in the workshop was the need to stay connected to a group of professional peers who provide support, as well as opportunities to share ideas, learn together, and increase the sense of belonging.

There was also the sense that arts therapists could take responsibility and lead change. From the first session of the workshop, the voices speaking of the value and meaning of this work were loud and clear. When the co-researchers were asked to choose a song or poem expressing their experience within the education system or to choose a song or poem expressing hope, most of the selections reflected professional strength, the powerful therapeutic process, and hope. This was surprising in light of the fact that we usually hear complaints about the challenges and difficulties, both in conversations with therapists and in research (Snir et al., 2018). Previous studies have revealed a connection between optimism and the belief that things can improve, and activism and the ability to create change (Carver & Scheier, 2012). It is possible that the invitation to create change produced a group of strong, motivated, and optimistic women who were ready to take action and responsibility; this may also explain the co-researchers' hope, faith, and belief in the value of their profession.

Courses of action

Group discussions during the program revealed the extensive activity already taking place in the field. Many RSCs are implementing projects to increase professionalism, reduce attrition, and enhance arts therapists' sense of belonging. Despite a lack of resources and energy, and notwithstanding the system's many regulations and restrictions, professionals in the field are finding creative ways to enrich and promote therapeutic practice. In recent years, reports on such projects have begun to appear in the literature. For example, Roginsky and her colleagues (Roginsky et al., 2021) described situations in which therapists

implement arts-based interventions within educational frameworks in accordance with the principles of the community approach. According to this approach, projects that are designed to examine the broader needs of the community are implemented within educational institutions, sometimes leading to interesting collaborations between arts therapists and teachers. These projects add diversity to the work of the therapists and provide additional opportunities for collaboration with educational professionals. At the same time, it is important to note that inviting therapists to act does not release decision-makers from their responsibility to improve the situation through the allocation of additional resources. However, the creativity and resourcefulness shown by Israeli arts therapists can serve as a model for therapists elsewhere, encouraging them to seek innovative solutions within their own educational contexts.

Significance of participating in a program involving action research

The sense of togetherness created in the in-person meeting between equals and the sharing that took place helped the co-researchers 'stand tall.' The process of allowing themselves to feel overwhelmed and recognizing the difficulties also highlighted shared values and the sense of mission. The common language created, the feelings of mutual understanding, and a shared experience were all elements that provided strength. Similarly, responding to an invitation to design and participate in a study and then co-author an academic article were rewarding activities for these co-researchers. Studies in the field of psychotherapy show that participating in research may be beneficial for therapists (Grafanaki, 2012; Halvorsen et al., 2020; Taubner et al., 2012). For example, a qualitative study examined the experiences of 11 psychotherapists who, in collaboration with researchers, designed and conducted a study based on their clinical experience (Castonguay et al., 2010). Findings showed participation in the study enriched their perceptions of themselves and others and gave them the sense of belonging to an initiative that supported their profession. In a preliminary study in the field of arts therapies, Snir et al. (2023) described the perceptions, attitudes, and experiences of arts therapists working in the educational system who took part in the study. Among other things, they found participating in the research significantly contributed to shaping the therapists' professional identity. The findings of the present study add to the pool of research by underscoring the significance of participating in a study and showing how this can be a tool in arts therapists' empowerment.

The program introduced the arts into some of the group activities. These interventions seemed to help the co-researchers relax and enjoy themselves, while at the same time gaining a more profound understanding of the processes that took place during the workshop. In their feedback at the end of the program, the co-researchers said the music and visual art exercises helped them to gain perspective and renewed their belief in the healing power and the benefits of arts therapies. The empowerment and professional growth reported by these Israeli arts therapists highlight the potential benefits of participatory action research for arts therapists in general, offering a valuable model for professional development and resilience.

Implications

The findings reveal the clear advantages of integrating arts therapies into the education system, including the positive experiences of therapists who work in this system, but they also identify challenges that need to be addressed at higher levels. Arts therapists who participated in this study, both interviewees and co-researchers, wanted to continue to shape their professional identity within the system. However, insights that could help them lack clear conceptualization and are not effectively communicated to the educational staff or to arts therapists. Academic institutions that train arts therapists play a role in preparing them for the unique school environment, but the education system must facilitate

their integration, while strengthening their position through constant dissemination of information among supervisors and management and by offering a structured onboarding process in the RSCs. At the same time, policy makers should review and modify job definitions, compensation, and working conditions to reduce burnout and ensure provision of quality arts therapies to children and youth in the public education system. Although we focused on the Israeli context, these concerns extend beyond Israel to include all educational systems where arts therapists are integrated into schools and should be addressed by policy makers.

At the same time, arts therapists in the field can have a positive impact on both their working conditions and their professional development. This study underscores the substantial motivational impact of group dynamics and a sense of togetherness and suggests the exchange of information fosters this togetherness.

Conclusion

This study offers critical insights into the experiences of arts therapists within the education system, highlighting both their profound sense of mission and their significant challenges. It underscores the need for systemic reforms to improve working conditions, reduce burnout, and enhance job satisfaction for these professionals. While institutional support and policy changes are crucial, the resilience and initiative shown by arts therapists themselves can play an equally important role in driving positive change.

Research limitations and suggestions for further research

The initial processing of the 142 interviews conducted with colleagues offered a broad picture of the work experiences of arts therapists in the education system. At the same time, the 20 interviewers, i.e., co-researchers in this study, conducted the analysis of these interviews; therefore, their subjective views may have influenced the results. While certain co-researchers said the perspectives they conveyed on behalf of their RSC colleagues might not necessarily reflect their own, and that they were able to listen to and represent these different opinions as instructed, it is important to regard the positions and perceptions presented in this paper as a partial snapshot of more complex and nuanced realities. Inquiring into the experiences of additional arts therapists is important to gain insights into the challenges confronting therapists who may lack the resources to advance their careers or those who have opted to leave the system. Since the current study presents initiatives designed to create change, but not their implementation, subsequent studies could focus on the progress of projects aimed at mitigating burnout in the field, addressing both challenges and accomplishments.

The research was conducted in Israel and similar studies should be conducted in other educational settings. However, the findings and insights have implications for the integration of arts therapists in schools worldwide, offering valuable lessons for educational systems globally.

Declaration of Generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the writing process

During the preparation of this work the authors used ChatGPT in order to edit the text. After using this tool/service, the authors reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the publication.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data Availability

The data that has been used is confidential.

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